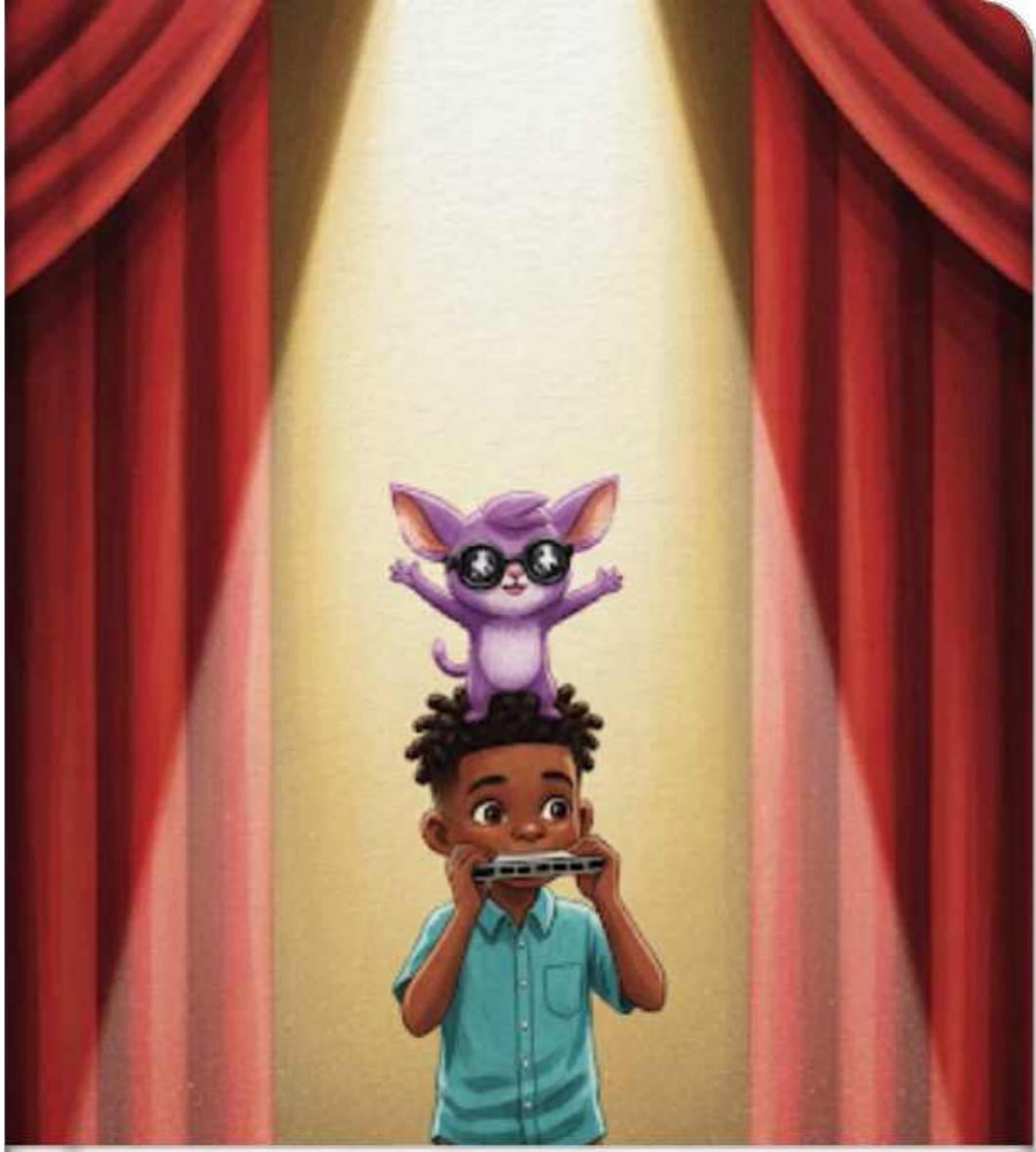
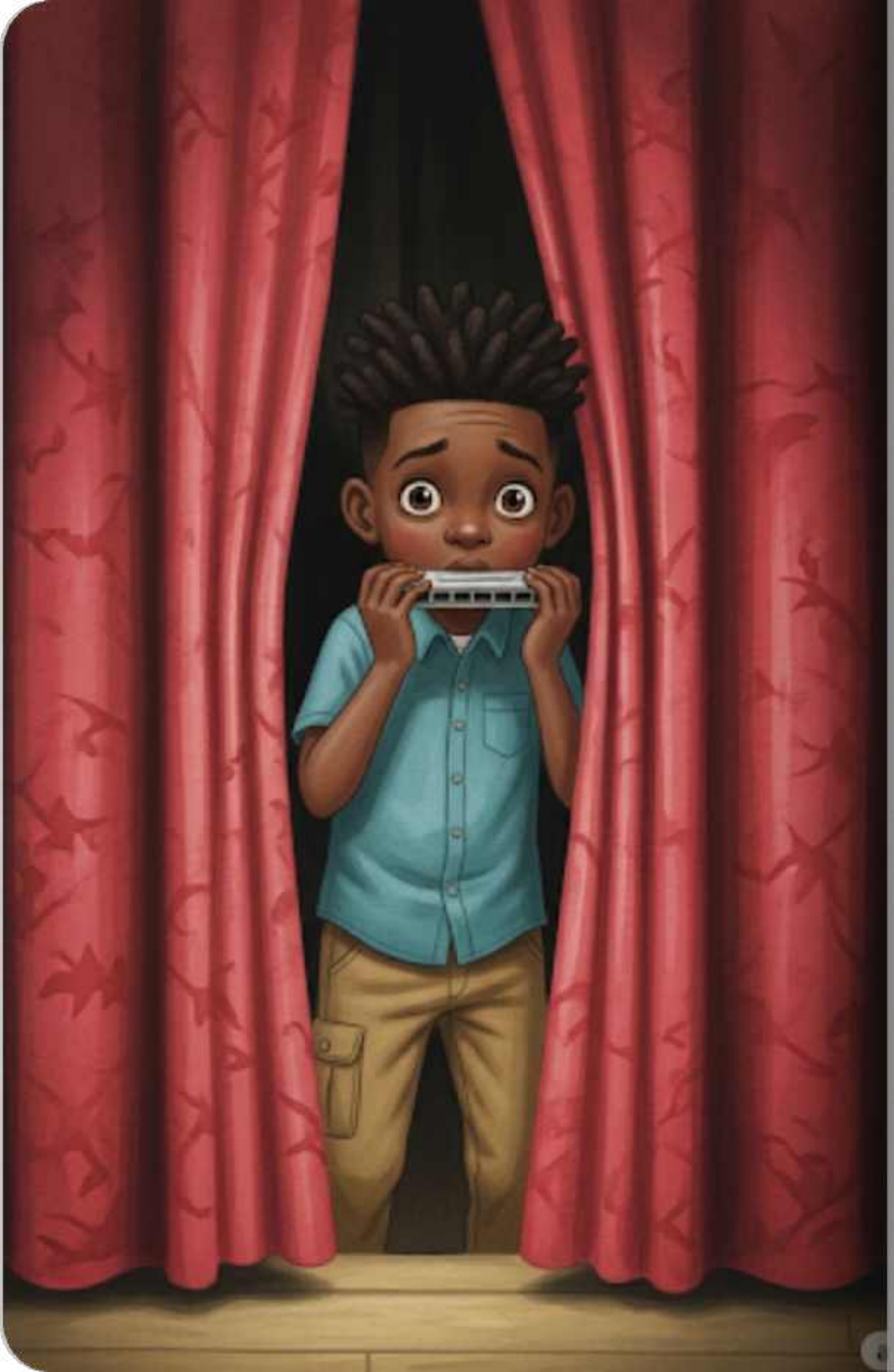


Arlo and the Tiny Bodyguard

By Kshipra

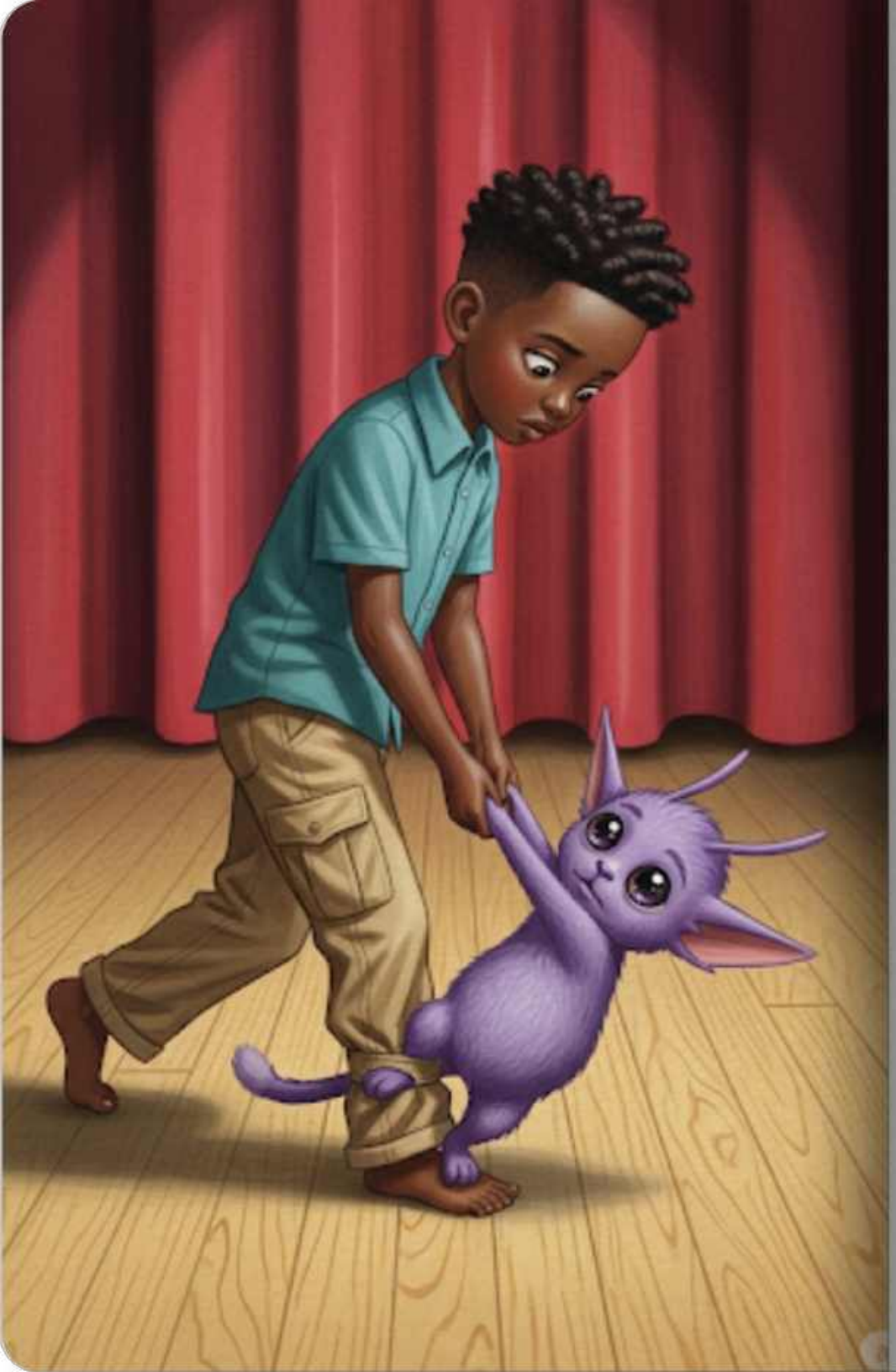


Arlo stood behind the heavy red velvet curtain of the school stage. In his hands, he clutched a shiny silver harmonica. Tonight was the Big Talent Show, and his heart was thumping like a drum. "Thump-thump! Thump-thump!" It felt

Suddenly, a small purple head popped out of Arlo's shirt pocket. It was Twitch, Arlo's very own Fear. Twitch had large, shimmering eyes and long, floppy ears that vibrated whenever he was worried—which was almost always.

Twitch jumped out and began pacing back and forth on a nearby equipment crate. He pulled out a tiny, hand-drawn map. "My job is to keep you safe, Arlo! And according to my calculations, that stage is full of 'What-Ifs.' What if you forget the song? What if you trip on your shoelaces? What if everyone transforms into giant hamsters?"

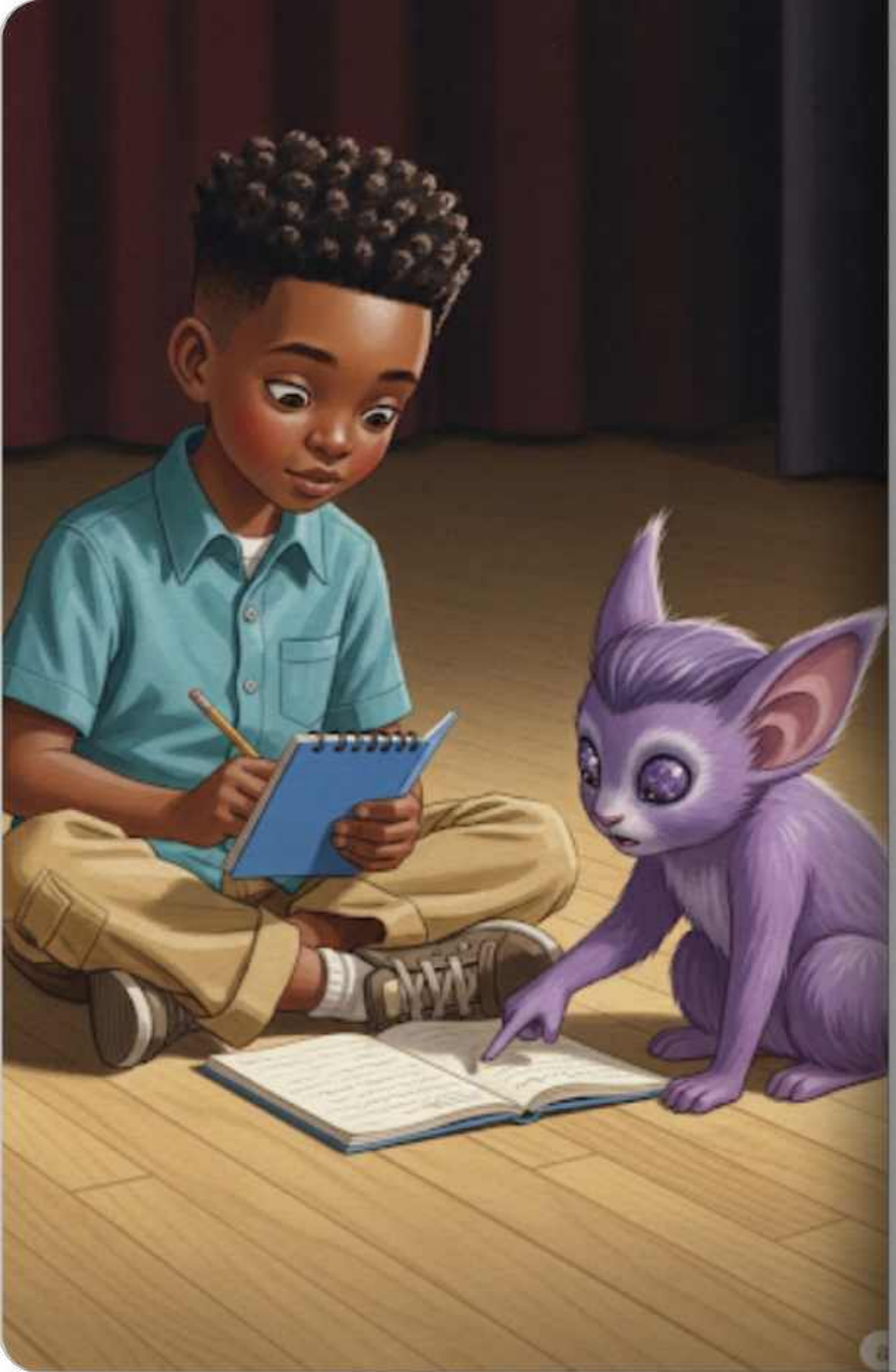
Arlo looked toward the dark hallway leading to the stage. To Twitch, every shadow looked like a lurking monster. Every whisper from the audience sounded like a secret plot. Arlo felt his legs turn to jelly. Maybe Twitch was right. Maybe the safest place to be was right here, hidden behind the curtain forever.



As Arlo took a tiny step toward the stage, Twitch dove down and grabbed onto Arlo's sneaker with all his might. "Wait! It's too risky!" Twitch cried. "The floor might be made of invisible trapdoors! We should stay here and eat your emergency granola bar instead!"

Arlo knelt down so he was eye-to-eye with the little purple creature. "I know you're trying to help, Twitch," Arlo said softly. "You want to protect me from getting hurt or embarrassed. That's a big job for such a small guy. But sometimes, you see monsters where there are just shadows."

Arlo reached into his back pocket and pulled out a small flashlight. He clicked it on and pointed the beam at a tall, jagged shape in the corner that Twitch had been pointing at. "Look," Arlo said. The light hit the shape, revealing it wasn't a monster at all—just a wooden coat rack holding a bunch of scarves.



Twitch squinted at the coat rack and let out a long breath. "Oh. It's... it's just laundry." Arlo smiled and pulled out a notebook. "Let's make a deal, Twitch. We'll make a Safety Checklist. We check the floor —no trapdoors. We check the laces—double knotted. If we check the facts, will you help me be brave?"

Arlo stepped into the spotlight and played his harmonica. The music filled the room, beautiful and clear. He didn't trip, and no one turned into a hamster. When he finished, the crowd cheered. Twitch stood on Arlo's head, waving his tiny arms in